

Ancient Egyptian sculpture

From c.3,300–330 BCE, the ancient Egyptian civilization thrived along the River Nile. Throughout that time, its art hardly changed. Following major concerns about religion and death, it was distinctive and ordered, with everything following strict rules of representation. There was no place for individual artistic interpretation. Most Egyptian art was not meant to be seen by the living. It was mainly created to help the deceased nobility reach the afterlife, and despite the inflexible approach, figures had to look credible. Sculpted reliefs followed set formats, with buildings, animals, heads and limbs portrayed from the side, torsos and eyes from the front. Statues were also stylized: faces looked ahead, bodies were straight, and size was used to indicate status.

Materials used included sandstone, granite, alabaster, basalt, ivory and iron. Even mud from the River Nile was moulded, baked and glazed. Hard stone statues were polished with crushed sandstone; softer stone was covered in stucco and painted.



Pharaoh Menkaure flanked by Egyptian goddesses, c.2500 BCE